

The Big Spender

JULY 20, 2009

A firm believer in the role of the state, Finance Minister Pranab Mukherjee borrows and bets on rural India to deliver growth.



“With his Budget, Mukherjee has not only confined Indian corporate tycoons inside a bird's nest but has also given a great fillip to the *aam aadmi* by defining what a dream budget really means.”

THARCIUS S. FERNANDO, *Chennai*

Spending Right

Your cover story (“The Big Spender”, July 20) had a good analysis of the Budget. Agreed, the middle class, whose expectations are always on the higher side, is naturally disappointed at the meagre raise in the tax exemption limit. But it is also true that “the tax proposals in the Budget benefit the rich more”. This Budget is in favour of rural people but is not so much for the urban *aam aadmi* who too has helped the UPA come to power. Coming in recessionary times, it is a good Budget and there is no guarantee that any other finance minister would have done any better.
BIDYUT KUMAR CHATTERJEE,
Faridabad

The lead story offered the right assessment of the



Gay and Loving It

The Delhi High Court's decision to decriminalise homosexuality is a judgement with far-reaching implications (“Celebration with Caution”, July 20). By striking down a centuries-old law, we are proud to have forayed into 21st Century. But the ambiguities are aplenty. Homosexuals are seen as objects of ridicule by many. Gay men are often forced to marry and lead a heterosexual life. A bigger challenge would be to fight these notions.

PREM K. MENON, *Mumbai*

The verdict on same-sex relations has opened a Pandora's box. Neither the Government nor the judiciary has the authority to decide the issue. A methodology to obtain a referendum should be evolved, or at least a group of eminent social scientists, legal experts and religious representatives of different sects should be entrusted with the responsibility of finding a consensus.

INDU SHANKAR, *Varanasi*

Union Budget 2009. It is a political budget which makes higher allocations for flagship schemes aiming at inclusive growth, combating the economic meltdown and goes slow on reforms. Pranab Mukherjee has taken a huge risk. If the benefits reach the targeted groups, the risk would be worth taking. But for that to happen, major administrative reforms will be needed.

A. JACOB SAHAYAM,
Thiruvananthapuram

Tackling Terror

Your story on India's anti-terror response (“India Unprepared”, July 20) is a timely update on the Government's inadequacy in protecting the country's land, air and sea from terror threats in spite of higher budgetary provi-

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